HCV SURVEILLANCE

Is Kenya experiencing a rise in active HCV infections?



What does the evidence tell us?

NATIONAL SCREENING DATA

What do the numbers tell us?

HCV screening positivity

2020	2022	2023
2.6%	1**.5%**	1**.7%**
Positive	Positive	Positive

The key observation

Screening positivity rose slightly in 2023, but remained below the 2020 level.

Source: Kenya national progress report, KHIS screening data.

UNDERSTANDING THE RESULTS

A positive antibody test doesn't tell the whole story.



HCV antibody
Indicates previous or current exposure to HCV.



HCV RNA
Detectable RNA indicates current viraemic infection.

The key message

A positive antibody result requires follow-up testing for HCV RNA to determine whether infection is current.

LABORATORY MEDICINE · EPIDEMIOLOGY · DATA ANALYTICS

Source: WHO, Hepatitis C fact sheet.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

Active HCV infections have been documented in Kenya.

230 of 284

HCV antibody-positive participants had detectable HCV RNA in a Kenyan study.

The study involved people who inject drugs across coastal Kenya, Nairobi and western Kenya.

What this tells us

Active infections and transmission have occurred in these study populations. This does not establish a nationwide increase.

Source: Kenyan HCV cohort study, 2019. Read the study

THE EVIDENCE GAP

Are new, active HCV infections increasing nationally?

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The evidence is not yet conclusive.

An increase in antibody-positive screening results does not, by itself, establish an increase in new active infections.

What would help answer the question?

- ✓ Comparable annual HCV RNA-positive results.
- ✓ Reliable incidence estimates across multiple years.
- ✓ Consistent testing coverage and reporting methods.

Sources: WHO hepatitis guidance and Kenya national screening reports.

THE TAKEAWAY

A pattern is a starting point, not a conclusion.

Observe. Investigate. Analyse. Validate. Then conclude.

Four disciplines. One evidence-based approach.



Laboratory Medicine

Epidemiology

Public Health Surveillance

Data Analytics

Good public health decisions begin with good evidence.